PAGE E · FOR YOU ONLY · NOT LINKED, NOT INDEXED

Standing up a domain

Every step, in order, with your own values filled in. Tick things off as you go — this page remembers your ticks in this browser, which is the one place in the whole project that stores anything. Do exactly what is here and nothing else; the optional-looking extras on these sites are where the afternoon goes.

You no longer have to do this by hand. `2 - NEW SITE.command` ⧉ in `three-columns-tools` ⧉ performs every step below automatically: it creates the repository, pushes the files, turns on Pages, sets the custom domain, writes the nine DNS records at Cloudflare, waits for propagation, waits for the certificate and turns on HTTPS.

This page is kept for three reasons: it is the record of *what* the script does, so nothing about the arrangement is hidden; it is the fallback when the script cannot run or the registrar has no API; and section **E7** — what the failure messages actually mean — applies either way. Work through it by hand only if you have reason to.

THE DOMAIN YOU ARE SETTING UP

`gyro-sites.online`

GITHUB USERNAME OR ORG

`FB-Decipherer`

NEW REPOSITORY NAME

`threecolumns`

Everything below rewrites itself from these three. Click any boxed value to copy it.

Read this before you touch anything. A repository publishes to *one* custom domain — the domain lives in a file called `CNAME` ⧉ in the repository root, and that file holds one name. **baconian-ciphers** already carries baconian-ciphers.online, so `gyro-sites.online` ⧉ needs its own new repository. That is what step 2 is. Trying

> to add a second domain to the existing repository is the one mistake that will cost you a whole afternoon.

E1 Buy the domain

Namecheap, as before. Ten minutes, and the only money involved.

1. Search for `gyro-sites.online` and buy it. Decline every upsell — you do not need their hosting, their email, their SSL, or their "premium DNS." You are using none of it.
2. **Leave WhoisGuard / Domain Privacy ON.** It is free and it keeps your home address out of the public registry.
3. Turn on **two-factor authentication** on the Namecheap account if it is not on already. Your registrar account is one of only two things anyone can actually steal from you.
4. In the domain's dashboard, confirm **Nameservers** is set to `Namecheap BasicDNS`. If it says anything else, change it to that — the records in step 3 only work if Namecheap is answering for the domain.

E2 Make the repository

1. On github.com: **New repository**. Name it `threecolumns`. Tick **Public**. Do not add a README, a license, or a .gitignore — an empty repository is easier.
2. Open **GitHub Desktop** → **File** → **Clone repository** → pick `threecolumns` → choose where it sits on your machine.
3. Copy `index.html`, `setup.html`, `domain.html` and `links.json` into that folder.
4. In GitHub Desktop: type a Summary line, **Commit to main**, then **Push origin**.

5 On github.com, in the new repository: **Settings** → **Pages**. Source: **Deploy from a branch**, branch `main`, folder `/ (root)`. Save.

6 Wait a minute, then check the plain address works before you involve the domain at all: `https://fb-decipherer.github.io/threecolumns/`

> **Stop here until that address loads.** If it does not, the problem is the repository or the Pages setting, and it has nothing to do with DNS. Fixing it now saves you from debugging two things at once.

E3 The DNS records

Namecheap → **Domain List** → **Manage** → **Advanced DNS** → **Host Records**. Delete whatever parking records are already there — usually a CNAME on `www` and a URL Redirect on `@`. Then add these ten. Verified against GitHub's own documentation, 10 September 2026.

TYPE	HOST	VALUE	TTL
A	@	`185.199.108.153`	Automatic
A	@	`185.199.109.153`	Automatic
A	@	`185.199.110.153`	Automatic
A	@	`185.199.111.153`	Automatic
AAAA	@	`2606:50c0:8000::153`	Automatic
AAAA	@	`2606:50c0:8001::153`	Automatic
AAAA	@	`2606:50c0:8002::153`	Automatic
AAAA	@	`2606:50c0:8003::153`	Automatic
CNAME	www	`fb-decipherer.github.io.`	Automatic

> **The CNAME value ends in a dot.** `fb-decipherer.github.io.` — trailing dot included. Namecheap will usually add it for you, but check afterwards; a missing

dot is the commonest silent failure here. Note also it is your *username*, not the repository name.

The four AAAA records are new since we last did this and are worth adding — they serve visitors on IPv6 connections, which is most phones on mobile data.

THEN WAIT — USUALLY 10 TO 30 MINUTES, OCCASIONALLY MUCH LONGER

1. Records entered and saved.

2. Check they have spread before going further: dnschecker.org → enter `gyro-sites.online` → type **A**. You want the four addresses showing green in most locations.

E4 Attach the domain to the site

Correcting our own notes. The old instruction said always set DNS first or GitHub shows a red warning. GitHub's own documentation actually asks you to enter the domain in Settings first and then create the records. Both work. Doing DNS first, as above, simply means you are less likely to meet the red warning at all — and if you do meet it, it is not an error, it is impatience.

1. In the new repository: **Settings** → **Pages** → **Custom domain**. Enter `gyro-sites.online` — no `www`, no `https://`. Save.

2. GitHub writes a `CNAME` file into the repository itself. You do not create it by hand. In GitHub Desktop, **Fetch origin** so your local folder picks it up, or your next push will conflict.

3. Watch for the green tick beside the domain. If you see `DNS check unsuccessful`, press **Check again** every few minutes. It clears itself once the records have propagated.

E5 The padlock

1. Leave it alone. A certificate is requested automatically once the DNS check passes.
2. When **Enforce HTTPS** becomes tickable, tick it.

OFTEN 15 MINUTES — GITHUB DOCUMENTS IT AS UP TO 24 HOURS

Our old note said "a few minutes," which is usually true and occasionally very wrong. If the box is greyed out with a message about the certificate still being provisioned, that is normal and there is nothing to do. Come back tomorrow before assuming anything is broken.

E6 Check it, then stop

1. `https://gyro-sites.online` loads.
2. `https://www.gyro-sites.online` loads and redirects to the bare domain.
3. The padlock is showing and the address stays on `https`.
4. It looks right on the phone.

> **Then you are finished, and you never do this again for this domain.** From here publishing is: edit the file, Commit, Push. The certificate renews itself. The DNS stays as it is. Nothing expires except the domain, once a year, and Namecheap will email you.

E7 When it looks broken

Almost always one of these five, and almost always waiting rather than fixing.

"DNS check unsuccessful"

Not an error. The records have not spread yet. Press **Check again** in a few minutes. If it is still saying it after a couple of hours, the records are wrong — go back to E3 and check the trailing dot on the CNAME and that Nameservers really is BasicDNS.

A 404 from GitHub on the new domain

DNS is working and Pages is not. Check **Settings → Pages** still shows the branch and root folder, and that `index.html` is at the top of the repository rather than inside a subfolder.

The old site appears, or a Namecheap parking page

Cached, or a leftover record. Delete any URL Redirect record on `@`, then try in a private window.

You changed a file and the page has not changed

Ten-minute cache. Add `?v=1` to the address, then `?v=2`, and so on. Do not start editing to fix a problem that is only a cache.

"Enforce HTTPS" is greyed out

The certificate has not been issued yet. Nothing to do but wait, up to a day.

> **The rule for this whole page.** If something is not working, wait fifteen minutes before changing anything. Nearly every wasted hour in this kind of work is spent breaking a setup that was merely still propagating.

E8 Afterwards

1. Two-factor authentication on **both** the GitHub account and the Namecheap account. These are the only two things that can actually be taken from you.
2. Put a note in your calendar a month before the domain renews. Registrars send reminders; reminders go to spam.
3. Record the date you did this at the foot of the site's technical column, so the next person — including you in two years — knows how old the arrangement is.

Clear all ticks

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